line with the advice in its official media handbook for social-media managers. The handbook is surprisingly exhaustive on how to measure impact and asks party workers to use measurement tools as diverse as Keyhole, Lucidya, Mention, Audiense, Tweetreach, Followerwonk, Buffer, Sumall, Quintly, Cyfe, Klout, Viralwoot and Additomatic. It concludes by telling its users, 'This isn't an ordered list—all of these apps are great. Give a few of them a try and gain some insights that will help you reach your goals!'[41]

So, how did the Congress assess its social-media strategy after the 2019 election? When I put this question to senior Congress leader and the party's chief whip in the Rajya Sabha, Jairam Ramesh, he was candid about the gaps. Ramesh, who held several ministerial portfolios in the previous UPA government, helmed the party's poll campaign coordination in 2004, 2009 and 2014, and was part of its nine-member core group committee for the 2019 Lok Sabha elections. Chatting over tea in his book-lined government apartment in central Delhi's Lodhi Estate, he agreed that the 'gap was closed in 2019, no doubt about it'. He said, 'The disparity in the campaigns on social media was not as great as it was in 2014. We caught up fairly well on Twitter.' However, he conceded that 'we were heavily outflanked on Facebook and even more outflanked on Instagram. On Instagram, Facebook and WhatsApp, the BJP was decidedly ahead.'[42]

What about the Congress's gains on Twitter? The BJP's National Head for Information and Technology Amit Malviya responds with a dismissive wave of the hand. A former vice president at Bank of America and HSBC, Malviya is the son of an Army officer and quit a lucrative career in banking in his late thirties to take up a full-time position with the BJP in 2015. We met at his digital keycard-protected office at the BJP's headquarters in Delhi from where he plots the party's daily digital-media operations. 'First of all, my comparison is not with the Congress party,' he said. 'We don't even look at what they're doing because they're a farce. Rahul Gandhi's Twitter account is on steroids. I said this on record that his retweets are not organic. They are basically bot-driven. That is the reality. If the man was getting 10,000 retweets for every damn thing he said, then you should be more popular than the kind of popularity